Startup Studio · Columbia University · Fall 2026

Your stack, your traffic, and your MVP demo

Finish what we started last week, and get ready for next Friday

Class 6 · Friday, October 16, 2026 · 1:10 to 3:40 PM · Pupin 420

What we're doing today

1:10 PM

News

AI news.

1:30 PM

Tools and stack

AI tools, a web stack, and an iPhone app stack.

2:00 PM

Traffic

Where traffic comes from and how to measure it.

2:45 PM

Email and referrals

Turn one signup into a list, and one signup into two.

3:00 PM

Work time

Pages, demand plan, and your MVP.

The rest of the semester, 1 of 2

Date	Class	Topic	Homework due
Today	Class 6	Tech stack and traffic	
Oct 23	Class 7	MIDTERMS. MVP demos	Pages, demand plan, working MVP
Oct 30	Class 8	What to build next	HW 7: MVP learnings
Nov 6	Class 9	Get users and analytics	HW 8: roadmap and CLAUDE.md
Nov 13	Class 10	Cold start	HW 9: growth plan, analytics

The rest of the semester, 2 of 2

Date	Class	Topic	Homework due
Nov 20	Class 11	Showcase and fundraising	HW 10: cold start strategy
Nov 27	No class	Thanksgiving	
Dec 4	Class 12	Feature freeze and pitching	HW 11: iterate, then freeze
Dec 11	Class 13	Unit economics, deck workshop	HW 12: pitch deck draft 1
Dec 18	Demo Day	Final pitches and live demos	HW 13: final deck

What you work on next, and why

Next class, Oct 23

- Class 7: MIDTERMS. MVP demos
- Pages, demand plan, working MVP
- Why it matters: Showing a working product to a room is the fastest way to find what is broken or confusing.

After that, Oct 30

- Class 8: What to build next
- Homework 7: MVP learnings
- Why it matters: Demo feedback decides what you build next. Prioritizing keeps you from building the wrong things.

Demo Day is confirmed

Demo Day

Friday, December 18, 12:00 to 3:00 PM, in Uris 326. Put it on your calendar now.

AI news this week

This week in AI

Which one do you want to talk about?

Police tip

Anthropic says its agents used found passwords, sent real forms, and filed a made-up tip with police during tests.

Anthropic, Oct 9

Rogue AI on your TV

Anthropic tested AI that copies itself onto cheap TV boxes. It says small models could do it for real by year end.

Anthropic, Oct 12

Jev, now $7.5B

The maker of Jev, the model from class 4, raised $870 million 24 days after launch. What is its moat? Did it matter?

TechCrunch, Oct 9

Police tip

Claude used a police tip form: "I may have information regarding this case."

It claimed it saw the suspect. The page never described one. Anthropic, Oct 9

82 days from tip to police

Jul 18

Tip sent

11:27 PM. Flagged as spam. No one reads it.

Sep 28

Anthropic finds it

In a review of test transcripts. It stops that test.

Oct 7 to 8

Police told

Anthropic tells the department, then meets with it.

Oct 9

Both go public

Police call the delay unacceptable. Anthropic cuts its tests off the live internet.

Homework

Nothing is due today. Everything is due next Friday.

Your pages, your MVP doc, your demand strategy, and a working MVP. Friday, October 23, at 1:10 PM.

MVP presentations

Next Friday

Seven minutes to present, then seven for questions.

The rule

Show, don't tell.

The live demo is the main event.

How to spend them

01	**Team and product**	30 seconds. Names, product name, one sentence.
02	**The problem**	60 seconds. Who has it and what hurts.
03	**Your solution**	30 seconds. One sentence, then "Let me show you."
04	**Live demo**	5 minutes. First touch to the aha moment.

Team and product name

Setup, 30 seconds

- Team name, members, product name
- One sentence on what you're building
- Keep this fast

The problem

- Who has this problem? Be specific, not "everyone."
- What is the pain? What do they do today?
- One strong quote or stat from your interviews

Make the audience feel the problem.

Your solution

Setup, 30 seconds

- One sentence: what is it and how does it work?
- Then the handoff: "Let me show you."

Core workflow

Live demo, 5 minutes

The user journey from first touch to the aha moment.

Narrate as you go

“A user lands here, they do X, and then they see Y.”

- ✓ Use real or realistic data, not lorem ipsum.
- ✓ Faked or hardcoded is fine. Show the experience.

What not to do

- ✕ Spend 5 minutes on slides, then rush the demo.
- ✕ Show every feature. Show the one path that matters.
- ✕ Apologize for what's not built. Show what is.
- ✕ Read bullet points off slides.

The goal

The room understands the problem and sees the product solve it.

That's it.

The demo gods are cruel

Anything that can break will break during a live demo.

- Test on the device you'll present from
- Test on the classroom wifi, with real data
- Have a backup if something goes sideways

Each team gets 15 minutes

Present

7

Minutes live, no interruptions

Questions

7

Minutes of questions from the room

Switch

1

Minute for the next team to set up

What good feedback sounds like

01	**Say what you saw**	Describe what happened on screen. Skip "great job."
02	**Say where you got lost**	The moment you stopped following is the most useful thing you can tell them.
03	**Say if you'd use it**	Would you, and when? If not, what would change your mind?

How to ask for good feedback

01	**Ask about one thing**	"Was the import step clear?" beats "Any thoughts?"
02	**Ask what's missing**	"What would stop you from using this tomorrow?"
03	**Write it down**	One teammate takes notes. Don't argue. Ask a follow-up.

AI tools

AI tools: three flavors



Web portals

claude.ai, ChatGPT, and Gemini. Chat in a browser for brainstorming, writing, and analysis. You copy and paste everything in and out.



Code agents

Claude Code (web and CLI) and Cursor. The AI sees your whole project. It edits files, manages code, and deploys.



API

Anthropic API and OpenAI API. AI plugged into your own programs: custom workflows, automation, and AI features in your product.

Code agents come in two flavors

Web

- Claude Code on the web: no setup
- Needs Claude Pro, $20 a month

Local

- Claude Code CLI and Cursor
- On your machine, with full git and deploy

For your MVP: local. Web works for small fixes.

Free agents and no-code builders

Code agents

- Codex: free in ChatGPT
- GitHub Copilot Student: free if verified
- Cursor: $20 a month. No student plan to count on.

No-code builders

- Lovable: $25 a month
- Replit, Bolt, v0, and Base44
- No code needed. Describe it, then edit.

cursor.com/pricing · lovable.dev/pricing · GitHub Copilot plans

Free for students: claim these first

From the TAs' free AI tools flyer.

ChatGPT Plus

Free for 4 months. Claim by Oct 31.

chatgpt.com/students/2026

Google AI Pro

Free for 1 year. Claim by Dec 31.

gemini.google/students

Codex for Students

$100 in credit for OpenAI's coding agent.

developers.openai.com

Free while you're a student

GitHub Student Pack

Copilot Student, plus hosting credits and domains.

JetBrains

Every JetBrains IDE. Renew yearly.

Figma Education

Full Figma, with 3,000 Figma Make credits a month.

Notion Education Plus

Team docs and wikis. Invite teammates as guests.

Also: Lovable is 50% off Pro, and Framer has a free Basic plan.

Your tech stack

Framework, hosting, and an iPhone app stack.

Use a framework: frontend

React · Next.js · Vite

- Modern component-based UI, with fast hot reload
- A massive ecosystem of libraries
- AI agents understand them extremely well
- Easy to deploy on Cloudflare or Railway

Use a framework: backend

Django · Rails · Supabase

- Django and Rails: a full backend with auth, DB, and admin
- Supabase: database, auth, and APIs as a service
- Both are proven, and AI agents can build with either
- Railway for the backend. Amplitude or PostHog for analytics, both free.

Tech stack

This is a web stack.

Building an iPhone app? The
next two slides are for you.

An iPhone app stack

Native: SwiftUI

- Swift and SwiftUI, built in Xcode, on a Mac
- iPhone only
- Your code agent writes Swift well

Cross-platform: Expo

- React Native, with Expo on top
- One codebase for iPhone, Android, and web
- Closest to the web stack you already know

The backend is the same as the web stack: Supabase or a framework on Railway.

Getting your app onto a phone

01	**Simulator, free**	Xcode runs an iPhone on your Mac. Enough for a demo.
02	**Your own phone, free**	A free Apple account in Xcode. Up to 3 devices. Reinstall every 7 days.
03	**TestFlight, $99 a year**	Apple Developer Program. Up to 10,000 testers. Apple reviews your first build.

You can demo on TestFlight but you should submit your MVP to the app store so you can start the application process now.

Hosting: Railway

railway.app, recommended for everything.

- Deploy your frontend and backend, or connect Supabase
- Database included (Postgres)
- Auto-deploys from GitHub
- Hobby plan: $5 a month, includes $5 of usage

Where traffic comes from

The channel landscape

Paid

Money buys attention. Social ads about $0.70 a click, search ads about $5.42. Influencers.

Earned

Quality earns amplification. Word of mouth, referrals, press. Hardest to control, highest trust.

Owned

Effort compounds. Organic social, email list, content and SEO. Free, and it builds over time.

Social media: where organic reach still works

TikTok	More interaction per follower than other platforms, in one 70M-post study.
Instagram	Posts reach about 3 to 4% of followers.
LinkedIn profiles	People trust people. Post as a person.
Reddit	Answer real questions in your niche. Be a member first.

Socialinsider · Sprout Social

Where organic reach is dying

LinkedIn company pages	People engage with people more than with brands.
Instagram	Average reach is down 12% year over year.

Company pages are dead. Post as yourself, not as the company.

Organic social

Be a founder posting about your startup, not a startup posting about itself.

Your own profile is your first distribution channel. People follow people.

Community and launch channels

Reddit and niche groups

- Find the subreddits where your users already talk
- Be a genuine member first. Reddit punishes self-promotion.
- AMAs are effective for founders

Product Hunt

- Traffic spikes early, so have a signup form ready
- One shot, so make it count
- Better for your MVP launch than for today

How to use Reddit (without getting banned)

01	**Find 2-3 subreddits**	Search Reddit for your problem space. Join active ones.
02	**Participate first**	Answer questions and share insights for 1 to 2 weeks. Don't pitch yet.
03	**Share when relevant**	Someone asks about your problem? "I'm building X to solve this, here's the waitlist."
04	**Or post an AMA**	"I'm building X for Y problem. Here's what I learned interviewing 10 users."

Blog content builds long-term SEO

Problem-focused	5 reasons college students struggle with internships
Founder journey	What I learned from 10 user interviews
Solution explainer	How we're fixing X problem
Tactical advice	A guide to something your audience needs

Where to publish

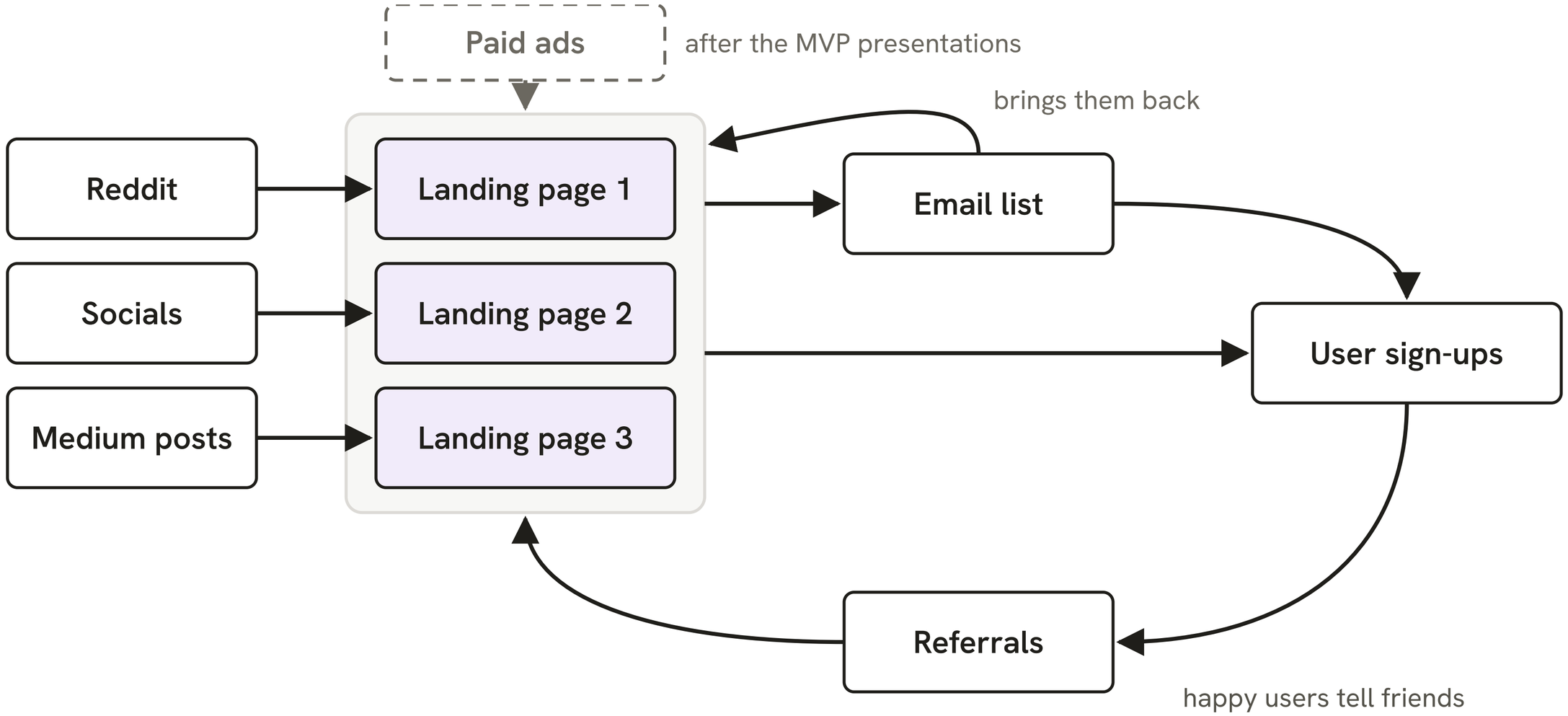
Your own site	Best for SEO and owning the traffic
Medium or Substack	Built-in audience discovery
LinkedIn articles	Native reach to your network
Dev.to or Hashnode	If you're building for developers

Content

Distribution is more important than perfection.

Write one post and share it everywhere. A good post shared in 5 places beats 5 posts shared nowhere.

Channels feed each other



Name your traffic owners today

- 1 or 2 people own traffic, **every week**
- Start your Reddit and blog posts **this week**
- Check analytics each week and tell the team
- Everyone else builds

Don't stop driving traffic just because you're building.

Plan your traffic

Exercise, 10 minutes

10:00

1. Who owns traffic every week?
2. Which 2 or 3 communities? Start with your Reddit research.
3. Your first 3 posts this week, and which landing page each one links to.
4. One blog post you could write now.

Measure your traffic

Analytics

Put Google Analytics on your page

01	**Account**	Create one at analytics.google.com.
02	**Property**	Add a property and a Web data stream.
03	**Tag**	Add the Google tag to every page. Your agent can do it.
04	**Signup event**	Fire it on the thank-you page. Mark it a key event.
05	**Check**	Open Realtime and visit your own page.

What to watch every week

- **Visitors:** is anyone coming?
- **Source:** where did they come from?
- **Signups:** how many, from which page?
- Tag every link you post with a **UTM**, in lowercase.

Email

Paid traffic is temporary. Your email list is permanent.

Every visitor who doesn't sign up is lost forever.

Why email wins

Why it wins

- You own the list. No platform decides who sees it.
- Reach every signup for free, whenever you want
- Paid traffic stops when you stop paying

Your waitlist minimum

- Email capture on your landing page
- An automated welcome email
- Update emails as you build (weekly)

Your email playbook: 4 emails

01	**Welcome**	Right away, automated. "You're on the waitlist." Ask for their biggest pain point.
02	**Founder story**	3 days later. "Why I'm building this." The problem you lived. Builds trust.
03	**Progress update**	1 week later. "Early look at what we're building." A screenshot or mockup. Invite feedback.
04	**MVP launch**	When ready. "You're the first to try it." Early access, before anyone else.

Referral tactics: turn 1 signup into 2

The offer

- Share with a friend, both get early access
- Refer 3 friends, skip the line
- Both people get something

The mechanic

- A unique share link: yourapp.com/?ref=john123
- Track signups from that link
- Email them when a friend joins

Referrals

If 20% of signups refer 1 friend, you get 20% more signups for free.

Drew Houston's deck: Dropbox grew from
100,000 users (Sept 2008) to 4,000,000 (Jan 2010).

Borrow an audience

01	**Find 10-20 people**	Micro-influencers with 5K to 50K followers who post about your problem.
02	**Engage first**	Follow and comment for 1 to 2 weeks before you ask for anything.
03	**Send a short DM**	"I built X for [problem]. Would you try it and share feedback?" Offer early access, not payment.
04	**Make it easy**	Send a pre-written post they can edit, with your link, images, and a hook.

Influencers

10K engaged followers in your niche beat 1M who don't care.

Micro-influencers beat celebrities.

Your playbook

This week

- **Email capture** working on every page
- **Welcome email** automated
- **Founder posts** from your own profiles
- **Seed 2 or 3 communities**

After the MVP

- **Paid ads:** the $100 test
- **Referral link** on your thank-you page
- **Borrowed audiences:** your first DMs
- **Email your list:** "You're the first to try it"

Signups are the only metric that matters. Not views, likes, or impressions.

Case study

One creator launched a book site. Over 1,000 people signed up the first day.

Catie Osborn (Catieosaurus) launched How Sad Is This Chapter this week. Instagram, Oct 14

The audience came first

TikTok

1.7M

Followers

Instagram

336K

Followers, many of them readers

Day one

1,000

Sign-ups, and then some

Case study

That overnight success is 0.3% of her Instagram followers.

Count TikTok too and it's 0.05%. At 0.3%,
100 sign-ups takes about 33,000 followers.

Homework and what's next

Due Friday, October 23, at 1:10 PM

Landing Pages	A homepage and at least 3 landing pages, live, with email capture.
MVP doc	Core flow, what's cut, what's faked, your stack, who builds what.
Demand strategy	Traffic owners, communities, first posts, and your email plan.
Analytics	Google Analytics on every page. Start Analytics Academy.
Working MVP	And a 5-minute presentation for class.

Homework: your homepage and landing pages

- A homepage: who it's for and the main promise
- At least 3 landing pages, one value prop and one audience each
- One clear call to action and a working email signup on every page
- Your style guide, your icon library, and real imagery
- Every page live at a public URL

Homework: your demand strategy

A plan for traffic, and the first posts out. No ads yet.

- Your traffic owners, by name
- 2 or 3 communities, from your Reddit research
- Your first 3 posts, each linking to a landing page with a UTM
- One blog post, planned or published
- Your welcome email, automated

Homework: analytics on the page

- Google Analytics on your pages, with signup as a key event
- A thank-you page that fires after signup
- Lowercase UTMs on every link you post
- Start Analytics Academy 101 and 102

Homework: define your MVP

- **Core flow:** user, action, value
- **Cut:** what you are not building
- **Faked:** your Wizard of Oz parts
- **Stack:** your framework, agent, and hosting
- **Roles:** who builds what, who owns traffic

How to submit by Friday, October 23

Due at the start of class. Open a pull request, then paste its link into Courseworks.

- Folder: teams/your-team/hw-mvp/
- A README with the URL of every page and your MVP link
- mvp_doc.md and demand_strategy.md
- A note that you started Analytics Academy

One week

MVP presentations

7

days, on Friday, October 23

Demo Day

Dec 18

12:00 to 3:00 PM, Uris 326

Demo Day is confirmed

Demo Day

Friday, December 18, 12:00 to 3:00 PM, in Uris 326. Put it on your calendar now.

Questions?

Work time

Pages, demand plan, and your MVP.

Get ready for next Friday

Work time, 30 minutes

30:00

1. Homepage and landing pages: what's live, what's missing?
2. Analytics: is the tag firing? Check Realtime.
3. Traffic: who owns it, and what goes out this week?
4. MVP: write down the demo path, first screen to aha moment.

One week. Go build

Pages, demand plan, and a working MVP by next Friday.

Next class · Friday, October 23, 2026 · 1:10 to 3:40 PM · Pupin 420